A Comparative Study of Attention-Enhanced Architectures for 3D Lung Nodule Detection in CT Scans

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***Abstract*—Identifying lung nodules in CT images is crucial for effective diagnosis and treatment planning. In this study, we implement RetinaNet , a one-stage object detection framework that employs Focal Loss to mark the extreme imbalance classes inherent in medical imaging. With a practical focus on improving object classification and localization, the model was trained with data and using 10-fold cross-validation for 200 epochs which achieved high recall and mean Average Precision (mAP). Following this path, we attempted modifications to the architecture by integrating attention-based modules such as Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) blocks, namely SE Bottleneck, SE-ResNet Bottleneck, and SE-ResNeXt Bottleneck, in place of conventional ResNet bottlenecks. We also evaluated a Vision Transformer (ViT) model as an alternative architecture. There was a significant boost in precision due to these changes in the first 40 epochs. Our findings suggest that the attention mechanisms implemented in 3D medical object detection could represent features much better, contributing positively to the model's performance.**

***Index Terms*—Lung nodule detection, RetinaNet, Squeeze-and-Excitation Networks, Focal Loss, Deep Learning, Computer-Aided Diagnosis**

I. Introduction

This research demonstrates a comparative study of various deep learning architectures using attention mechanisms to aid in the detection of lung nodule 3D CT scans [1] . Such attention-enhanced models aim to pay selective attention to relevant features from the convoluted medical images, thereby improving their performance in detecting those target structures. Compared to the 2D approaches, these 3D methods can analyze lung nodules more richly and realistically relative to the full spatial structure of the object across the slices of the image. The practical significance of the project lies particularly in the early detection of nodules, especially for lung cancer, this work aims to claim which attention-based strategies best enhance robust and sensitive nodule localization in CT imaging.

Lung cancer remains a leading cause of cancer-related mortality globally, and its prognosis is greatly influenced by early detection. Pulmonary nodules which are small spherical opacities in the lung are commonly the first signs of lung cancer, and their accurate detection is crucial for effective diagnosis in computer-aided diagnosis (CAD) systems. Computed Tomography (CT) imaging has become the standard modality for screening and identifying such nodules. Nonetheless, analyzing CT scans [1] manually is a time-intensive process and may lead to inconsistencies due to variations between observers and challenges due to the subtle appearance of nodules and the high number of slices per scan. Hence this necessitated the development of strong automation systems that would assist radiologists with reference to precision and sensitivity in detecting nodules.

Deep learning, particularly deep learning (CNNs), has revolutionized image analysis by automatically extracting complex hierarchical features from raw input data. Regarding object detection tasks, many CNN-based detectors have been widely investigated, such as Faster R-CNN [2] , YOLO [3] , Mask RCNN [4] ,DeepLung [5] ,DenseNet [6] ,etc. Among one-stage detectors, RetinaNet [7] , introduced by Lin et al., stands out as an attempt to deal with one of the significant problems in dense detection: the imbalance between the foreground and background classes. Instead, it has made use of the Focal Loss [8] function, which down-weights easy samples and puts the training center on hard, incorrect predictions. This innovation enables RetinaNet [7] to achieve accuracy on par with two-stage detectors while maintaining the speed advantage of one-stage frameworks.

In the context of medical imaging, where positive sam- ples (i.e., nodules) are sparse compared to the overwhelming background regions, the Focal Loss [8] becomes particularly beneficial. Using this, we implement and evaluate RetinaNet [7] on the dataset, a widely used benchmark for detecting nodules in 3D CT scans [1] . The model is trained using a 10-fold data splitting [9] for 200 epochs, thereby demonstrating high recall and mean Average Precision (mAP) values. This means it can be safely concluded that the model holds good promise for classification as well as localization of nodules.

To further enhance performance, we explore architectural improvements by integrating attention mechanisms. More specifically, we replace standard ResNet bottlenecks in the RetinaNet [7] backbone with Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) modules, including SE Bottleneck [10] , SE-ResNet Bottleneck [11] , and SE-ResNeXt Bottleneck [12] variants which are known to adaptively recalibrate channel-wise fea- ture responses, potentially improving feature representation in complex medical imaging scenarios. Additionally, a vision transformer (ViT) [13] -based architecture was also evaluated in the assessment of the effect of self-attention mechanisms for volumetric nodule detections.

Through these experiments, we aim to understand how attention-based enhancements influence classification accuracy and localization precision in a dense detection setting. The results, particularly in the early stages of training, show a significant precision gain with the addition of SE modules. Our work highlights the value of incorporating channel and spatial attention mechanisms into deep learning models for medical object detection, setting a direction for future improvements in CAD systems for lung cancer screening.

II. Related Work

A. Lung-YOLO

The YOLO [3] (You Only Look Once) family of models has been widely Utilized for analyzing medical images due to their real-time detection capabilities and simplified architecture. In the context of lung nodule detection, several studies have adapted YOLO [3] to process CT scans [1] , particularly by modifying the input pipeline to handle grayscale images and adapting the anchor boxes to suit the typical size range of pulmonary nodules.

YOLO's [3] strength lies in its single-stage detection mechanism, where both classification and localization are performed in a single pass through the network. This enables high inference speed and makes YOLO [3] suitable for real-time and resource-constrained deployment scenarios. Recent versions like YOLOv5 [14] , YOLOv7 [15] , and even lightweight variants like YOLOv5s [14] have been trained and tested on the dataset, achieving strong performance in detecting nodules.

However, one of the challenges with YOLO [3] -based detectors in medical imaging is their sensitivity to small objects, especially in cases where the nodules have low contrast or are located near complex anatomical structures. While techniques like feature pyramid networks and multi-scale training have improved small object detection, YOLO [3] still primarily relies on local spatial context and may miss subtle nodules that require deeper semantic reasoning.

Despite these limitations, YOLO [3] remains a competitive baseline for lung nodule detection due to its computational efficiency, and it serves as a useful reference point when evaluating more complex models like RetinaNet [7] and transformer-based detectors.

B. VitDet3d

With the growing interest in transformer architectures for vision tasks, models such as ViTDet3D [13] have emerged to address the limitations of convolutional approaches in 3D medical image analysis. ViTDet3D [13] extends the concept of the Vision Transformer (ViT) [13] to three-dimensional data, making it particularly well-suited for volumetric lung CT analysis, where understanding long-range spatial relationships is crucial.

Unlike CNN-based models, which typically extract local patterns through convolutional kernels, ViTDet3D [13] uses self-attention to model global context across all voxels or spatial tokens. This allows it to effectively capture inter-slice dependencies and subtle anatomical variations that might be overlooked by convolutional backbones. When applied to the dataset, ViTDet3D [13] has shown promising results in identifying hard-to-detect nodules, especially those located in complex regions like near vessels.

However, transformer-based detectors come with notable trade-offs. They typically require more data to generalize well and often involve heavier computational demands during both training and inference. This makes them less accessible for low-resource settings and more sensitive to overfitting on small medical datasets.

Despite these challenges, ViTDet3D [13] represents a forward-looking approach to medical image detection, offering a global reasoning capability that complements the strengths of CNN-based architectures. It stands as a valuable research direction, particularly for future systems where data and compute resources are less constrained.

III. Material and methods

A. Retinanet With Focalloss

RetinaNet [7] is a one-stage object detection system developed to challenge the severe imbalance of object and nonobject instances in the dense object detection task. The architecture of RetinaNet [7] comprises a backbone network, typically a ResNet-50 or ResNet-101, integrated with a feature pyramid network (FPN), i.e., employed to produce features at multiple spatial resolutions. These feature maps are then processed by two subnetworks: one for classification and another for regressing bounding boxes.

The backbone network processes the input image to extract the convolutional characteristics. The output from the backbone is further passed through an FPN. The FPN improves the backbone by creating a multi-scale feature pyramid that allows the detector to recognize objects at different scales. Each pyramid level is connected to both the classification and regression subnetworks. The classification branch estimates the likelihood of object presence across various spatial positions and resolutions, while the regression subnet predicts the coordinates of the bounding boxes.

A major advancement introduced in RetinaNet [7] is the Focal Loss [8] function, which effectively mitigates the issue of extreme class imbalance. This is achieved by reducing the contribution of well-classified examples to the total loss, thereby focusing the learning process on hard, misclassified examples. The Focal Loss [8] is mathematically defined as follows:

$$FL(p_t) = -\alpha_t(1 - p_t)^{\gamma} \log(p_t) \quad (1)$$

where p_t is the model's predicted probability for the correct class, α_t is a weight factor that adjusts the importance of positive and negative examples, and γ is a parameter that controls how aggressively easy examples are down-weighted. Essentially, this loss function helps the model focus more on the hard examples, which improves its ability to detect objects in imbalanced datasets.

B. Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) Blocks

Squeeze-and-excitation (SE) blocks improve the representational power of convolutional neural networks by introducing a channel-wise attention mechanism that allows the network to recalibrate feature responses adaptively. An SE block [16] operates in three stages: squeeze, excitation, and scale.

During the squeeze stage, Global average pooling is employed to compute statistics for each channel of the input feature map. This operation reduces Spatial data into a vector that describes each channel $z \in \mathbb{R}^C$, where C denotes the number of channels:

$$z_c = \frac{1}{H \times W} \sum_{i=1}^{H} \sum_{j=1}^{W} X_{i,j,c} \quad (2)$$

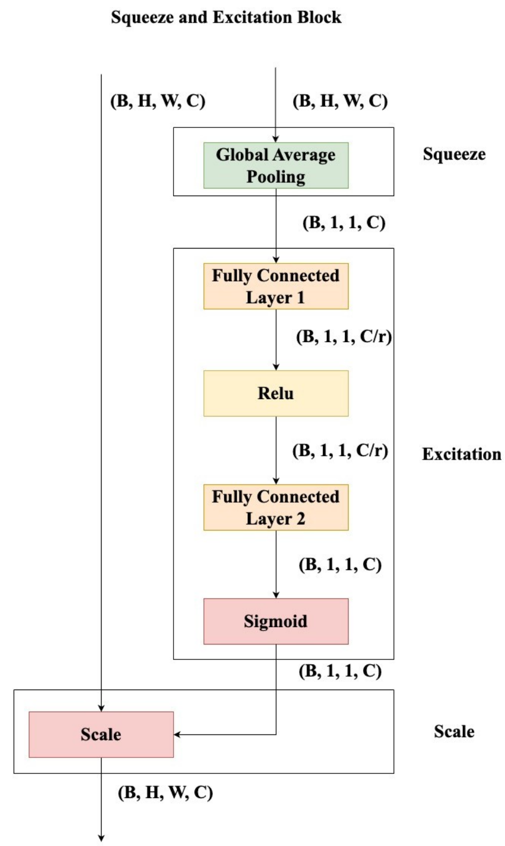


Fig. 1: Structure of a Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) block.

SE bottlenecks [10] are structurally similar to three-layer convolutional bottleneck design: It uses a 1 × 1 convolution to down-sample and then a 3 × 3 convolution to extract spatial features, and ends

with r 1×1 ution recove
anothe convol t o r

In the excitation stage, this descriptor is sent through a bottleneck consisting of two fully connected layers with a ReLU activation in between, succeeded by a sigmoid activation to produce weights based on the channel:

$$s = \sigma(W_2 \cdot \delta(W_1 \cdot z)) \tag{3}$$

In the scale stage, the original feature map is recalibrated by channel-wise multiplication with the weights s:

$$\tilde{X}_{i,j,c} = s_c \cdot X_{i,j,c} \tag{4}$$

This technique enables the network to focus on important features while disregarding less relevant ones, enhancing its ability to detect meaningful patterns.

C. SE Bottleneck

The SE bottleneck [10] is a modified bottleneck block that incorporates the Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) mechanism to improve the channel-wise feature recalibration. It serves as a core module in regularizing architectures such as SE-ResNet [11] and SE-ResNeXt [12] .

the original shape. Following these convolutions, an SE block [16] is added before the output is then added to the residual connection.

This design allows the network to extract features and to classify at different scales but also adaptively readjust channel-wise partition of more salient features for better response per size. This channel-wise attention approach is easy to use and can be easily incorporated into deep residual learning frame-

works with only a small overhead in terms of computational overhead.

D. SE-ResNet Bottleneck

SE-ResNet bottleneck [11] adds SE block [16] to the common ResNet architecture in order to improve its representational capacity. The inputs to the standard ResNet bottleneck follow several convolutions: a 1×1 convolution to do dimensionality reduction, a 3×3 convolution to do spatial processing, and a second, 1×1 convolution for dimensionality restoration. The output is then passed back into the original input using a residual connection.

An SE block [16] is inserted in the SE-ResNet bottleneck [11] after the last 1×1 convolution and before adding the residual connection. With this additional integration, the network adaptively recalibrates the channel-wise feature responses and improves its ability to model complex patterns.

E. SE-ResNeXt Bottleneck

SE-ResNeXt [12] combines the ideas of the SE blocks [16] and the ResNeXt architecture to push the performance of the network even further. ResNeXt introduces the idea of cardinality, which refers to the number of parallel paths (or groups) within a residual block. Each group performs a transformation on a subset of the input channels, and the outputs are aggregated to form the final output.

In the SE-ResNeXt bottleneck [12] , the grouped convolutions ResNeXt are followed by the SE block [16] , which recalibrated the feature maps aggregated together by the group. This combination exploits the different transformations given by the grouped convolutions and the adaptive channel-wise weighting power of the SE block [16] , resulting in a stronger and more efficient

F. Dataset

We used the Analysis of Lung Nodule 2016 (LUNA16) dataset [17] , which was derived from the publicly available LIDC-IDRI dataset. The LIDC-IDRI dataset contains Diagnostic and screening CT scans of the lungs for lung cancer collected from seven academic and medical institutions in the United States. From this database, the challenge selected 888 low-dose 3D chest CT scans for inclusion, each acquired from a unique patient.

In total, the dataset includes 1,186 nodules annotated across the 888 scans. The nodule diameters in this dataset range from 3 mm to over 30 mm, covering both subtle and conspicuous pulmonary lesions.

For model development and evaluation, the LUNA16 [17] challenge provides a standardized 10-fold cross-validation [9] protocol. Each fold divides the data to ensure that no patient is present in more than one fold, resulting in overlapping training and testing sets crossing the iterations. During our experiments, we ran the following setup: training on nine folds and validating the remaining fold in the rotating fashion. Such a rigorous approach guarantees statistical validity and lends to fair differentiation concerning different methods, all judged on the same dataset. The combination of expert annotations with diverse acquisition settings and challenging lesion characteristics makes the dataset a reference for evaluating lung nodule detection algorithms for low-dose chest CT scans.

IV. Experiments and Results

A. Data Pre-processing

For evaluating the proposed models, we employed the publicly available dataset which includes 888 low-dose thoracic CT scans, each annotated for pulmonary nodules. This dataset presents an invaluable means resource both in the domains of nodule classification and localization. It has gained wide popularity as a benchmarking dataset for lung nodule detection algorithms. They were rescaled to provide uniform voxel spacing of 0.703125 x 0.703125 x 1.25 mm in all images.

To facilitate training, we extracted 192×192×80 voxel patches centered around each candidate nodule, which were subsequently used for training the model. For model evaluation, we adopted a 10-fold cross-validation [9] strategy, where training was performed using nine folds, with the remaining fold reserved for testing. Each fold is tested exactly once. As a result, an unbiased estimate of model performance can be derived.

B. Evaluation Metrics

The performance of the models was assessed using both classification and localization metrics. For classification purposes, we employed recall. This metric provides a comprehensive evaluation of a model's ability to correctly classify nodules and non-nodules.

For localization, we used mean average precision (mAP). This metric evaluates the model's capability to correctly localize the nodule positions. Additionally, we computed the 3D Intersection over Union (IoU) to assess the overlap between predicted and ground truth bounding boxes in 3D space.

A crucial aspect of the evaluation was the Free-Response Receiver Operating Characteristic (FROC) analysis, which measures the sensitivity at different false positive rates per scan. The FROC curve provides a clear understanding of how the model performs under different levels of false positive tolerances, a critical consideration in medical imaging tasks where false positives can lead to unnecessary follow-up procedures.

Overall, our experimental results suggest that augmenting RetinaNet [7] with channel attention via SE blocks [16] leads to consistent improvements in both detection accuracy and robustness, especially under class-imbalanced conditions typical in lung nodule detection tasks.

C. Model Architecture

Three deep learning architectures were examined in this work, which mainly treats different aspects of lung nodule detection task: Baseline 3D CNN, which consists of many 3D convolution layers followed by pooling and fully connected layers, can be termed as naive model toward this architecture. Simple yet effective, and it is an undergirding model of performance comparison.

Then the improved version against the baseline model is a version that is called the SE-Bottleneck 3D CNN:Squeeze-and-Excitation (SE) Bottlenecks. The SE block [16] fine-tunes the capability of the network to focus on important features by recalibrating feature maps across channels, which has been known to improve performance for image classification and detection tasks because it adaptively chooses the muscular feature from the extracted feature maps.

Next is the hybrid model: convolutional and Vision Transformer (ViT) [13] integrated model known as ViTDet3D [13], exploiting the advantages provided by both of them. After

TABLE I: Comparison of Model Parameters

S.No	Model	Params (M)
1	RetinaNet BCE Loss [?]	20.90
2	RetinaNet Focal Loss [?]	20.90
3	ViTDet3D [?]	13.44
4	Focal Loss with SEBottleneck [10]	18.99
5	Focal Loss with SEResnet Bottleneck [11]	20.43
6	Focal Loss with SEResnext Bottleneck [12] [7]	21.23

feature extraction, a ViT [13] encoder will be tested on the resulting convolutional features that have local properties extracted through 3D convolutional layers and global dependencies as established through the self-attention mechanism of transformers. This model was designed to leverage the global context captured by transformers, which has been demonstrated to enhance performance in various medical imaging tasks. Overall, our experimental results suggest that augmenting RetinaNet [7] with channel attention via SE blocks [16] leads to consistent improvements in both detection accuracy and robustness, especially under class-imbalanced conditions typical in lung nodule detection tasks.

D. Results on LUNA16 Dataset

RetinaNet [7] trained with Binary Cross Entropy (BCE) loss achieved the highest performance, attaining a recall of 97.89% and a mean Average Precision (mAP) of 79.09% after 40 epochs. Figures 10–13 show the training loss, validation mAP, validation mAR, and recall graph for RetinaNet [7] . When trained with Focal Loss [8] , RetinaNet [7] achieved a recall of 97.30% and a mAP of 71.35%. The FL+SEB model achieved a recall of 94.5% and a mAP of 71.5%, while the FL+SEB-ResNet [11] and FL+SEB-ResNeXt variants exhibited a significant drop in both recall (approximately 54–55%) and mAP (approximately 39–40%). Figures 17–28 present the training loss, validation mAP, validation mAR, and recall graphs for RetinaNet [7] enhanced with SE Bottleneck [10] , SEResNet Bottleneck [11] , and SEResNext Bottleneck [12] variants.

The ViTDet3D [13] model achieved a recall of 77% and a mAP of 51.3%, indicating comparatively lower performance than the convolution-based models. Figures 14–16 show the training loss, validation loss, and recall graph for ViTDet3D [13] .

Overall, these results suggest that while feature recalibration using SE blocks [16] can offer some benefits, the standard RetinaNet [7] with BCE loss remains the most effective model for lung nodule detection on the LUNA16 [17] dataset. A detailed comparison of model parameters and performance across 20 and 40 epochs is summarized in Tables 1–3.

V. Discussion

The goal of this study was to evaluate the impact of architectural variations in the backbone of a RetinaNet [7] -based lung nodule detection model. Starting with the established ResNet bottleneck as the baseline, we experimented with three enhanced bottleneck variants—SEBottleneck [10], SEResNet

TABLE II: Comparison of Metrics on Luna16 Dataset for 20 epochs

S.No	Model	Epochs	Recall	mAP
1.	RetinaNet Focal Loss []	20	85.41	65.02
2.	ViTDet3D []	20	77	51.3

TABLE III: Comparison of Metrics on Luna16 Dataset for 40 epochs

S.No	Model	Epochs	Recall	mAP
1.	RetinaNet BCE loss []	40	97.89	79.0
2.	RetinaNet Focal Loss []	40	97.30	71.3
3.	Focal Loss with SEBottleneck [10]	40	94.5	71.5
4.	Focal Loss with SEResnet Bottleneck [11]	40	55.3	40.3
5.	Focal Loss with SEResnext Bottleneck [12] [7]	40	54.8	39.4

bottleneck [11], and SEResNeXt bottleneck [12] — to improve detection performance through better feature representation and attention mechanisms.

A. Role of CNNs in Medical Image Detection

Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) form the foun- dation of the RetinaNet [7] detection framework, playing a crucial role in automatically extracting hierarchical feature representations. Unlike traditional handcrafted approaches, CNNs learn spatial features directly from image data through convolutional layers. The backbone network influences the depth, resolution, and richness of extracted features, which are vital in detecting subtle structures like pulmonary nodules.

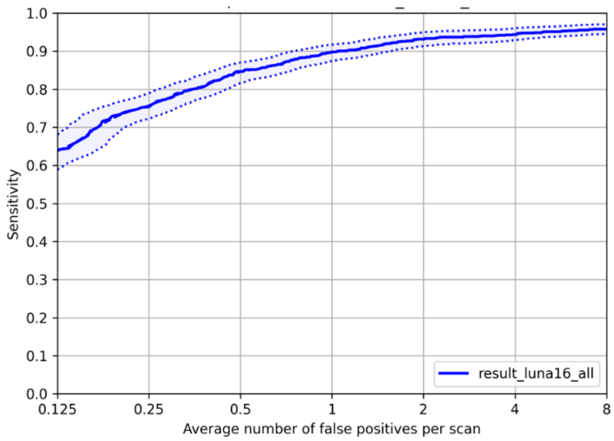
In the context of lung nodule detection, the strength of CNNs lies in their capacity to capture complex and subtle variations in nodule appearance. They can differentiate be- tween normal anatomical structures and potential nodules by learning discriminative patterns across spatial hierarchies.

Furthermore, CNNs offer a scalable solution for large-scale image analysis. Once trained, they can process CT slices in real time, making them suitable for integration into computer- aided diagnosis (CAD) systems. Their flexibility also allows for architectural enhancements—such as deeper layers, resid- ual connections, and attention mechanisms—which can further improve sensitivity and specificity.

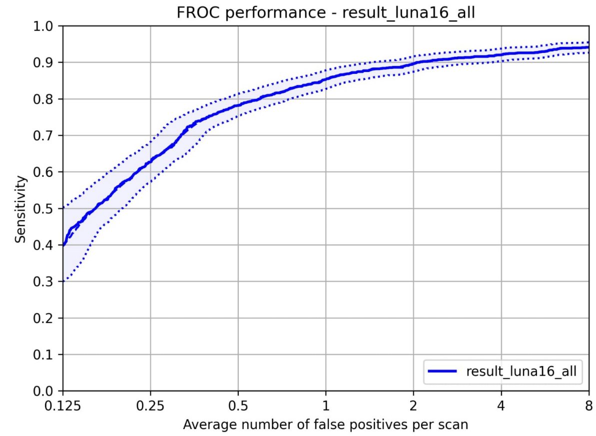
B. Baseline Model Analysis (ResNet Backbone)

The baseline ResNet bottleneck processes all feature chan- nels equally, which can limit its ability to suppress irrele- vant background noise or highlight diagnostically important regions. It provided strong overall performance but struggled with low-contrast nodules, complex anatomical structures, or nodules near the chest wall.

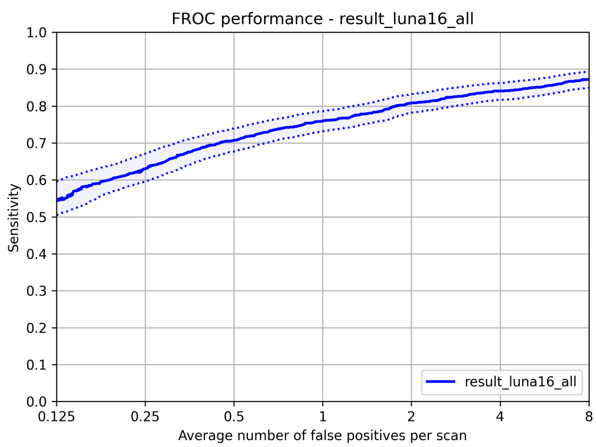
However, it revealed limitations when dealing with sub- tle nodules, overlapping tissues, or anatomical noise near lung boundaries. These shortcomings can be attributed to the uniform treatment of feature channels across layers, as ResNet lacks any mechanism to differentiate between highly informative and less relevant activations.



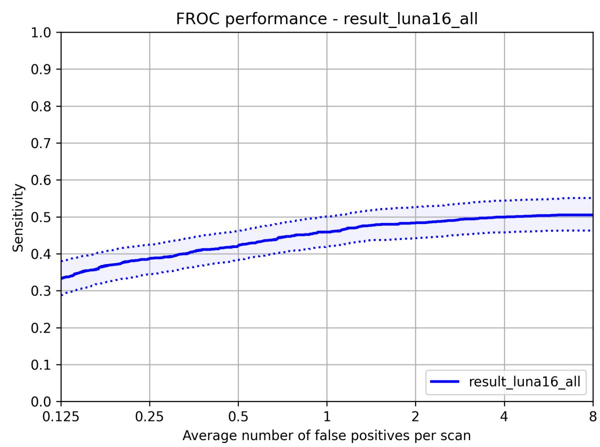
(a) Recall graph of RetinaNet (BCE Loss)



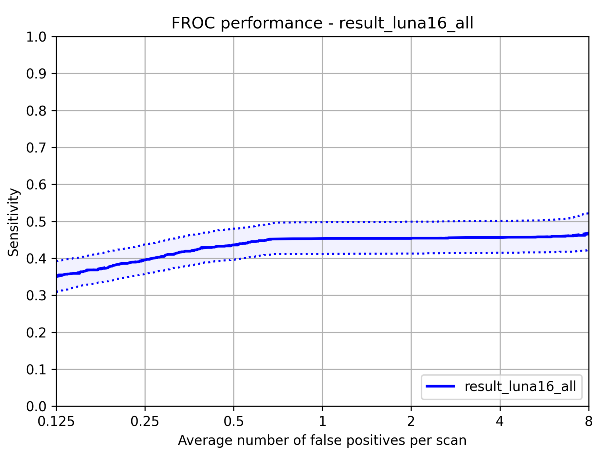
(b) Recall graph of RetinaNet (Focal Loss)



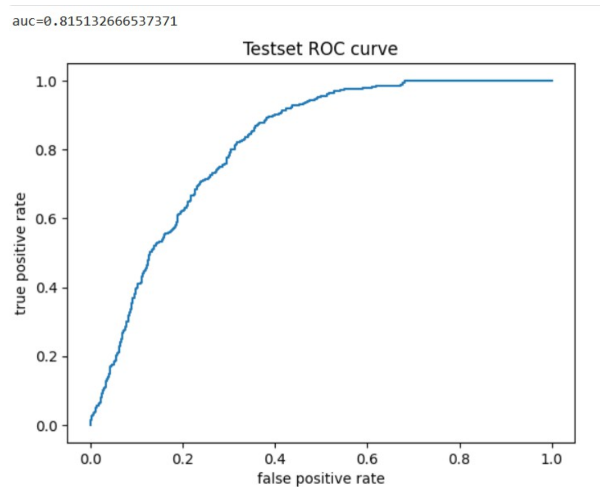
(c) Recall graph of RetinaNet with SE Bottleneck



(d) Recall graph of RetinaNet with SE ResNet Bottleneck



(e) Recall graph of RetinaNet with SE ResNeXt Bottleneck

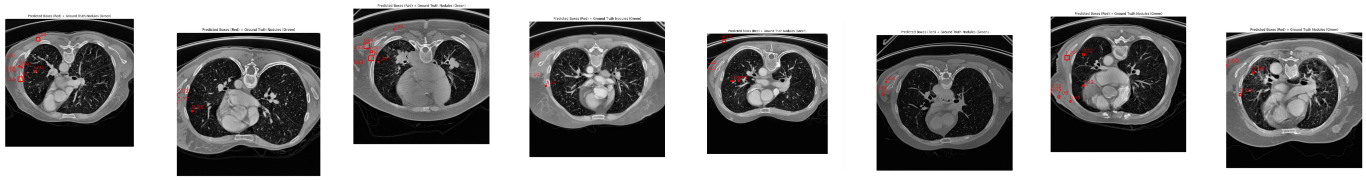


(f) Recall graph of ViTDet3D

Fig. 2: Comparison of Recall Graphs for Different RetinaNet Variants and ViTDet3D.

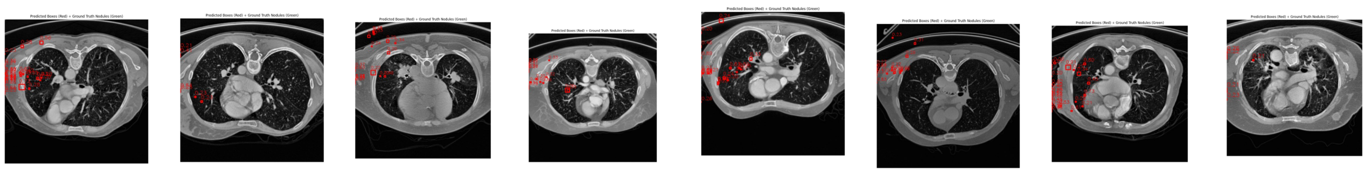
Moreover, without attention mechanisms, ResNet may distribute focus indiscriminately, making it harder to emphasize diagnostically important regions. While residual blocks help mitigate vanishing gradients, the extracted features remain purely spatial and non-adaptive.

This reinforced the need for more targeted feature refine-



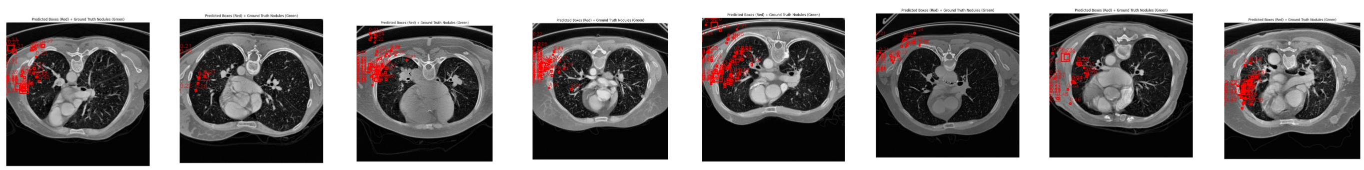
(a) BCE 1 (b) BCE 2 (c) BCE 3 (d) BCE 4 (e) BCE 5 (f) BCE 6 (g) BCE 7 (h) BCE 8

Fig. 3: Detection overview showing predicted nodule bounding boxes (red) using RetinaNet with BCE Loss on the LUNA16 [17] dataset.



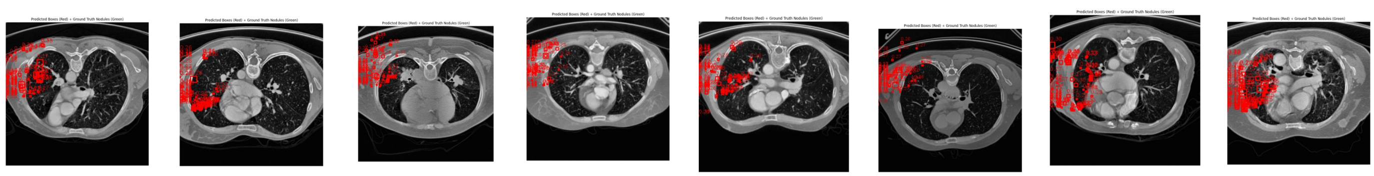
(a) FL 1 (b) FL 2 (c) FL 3 (d) FL 4 (e) FL 5 (f) FL 6 (g) FL 7 (h) FL 8

Fig. 4: Detection overview showing predicted nodule bounding boxes (red) using RetinaNet with Focal Loss on the LUNA16 dataset.



(a) SEB 1 (b) SEB 2 (c) SEB 3 (d) SEB 4 (e) SEB 5 (f) SEB 6 (g) SEB 7 (h) SEB 8

Fig. 5: Detection overview showing predicted nodule bounding boxes (red) using RetinaNet with Focal Loss and SE Bottleneck [10] on the LUNA16 dataset.



(a) SER 1 (b) SER 2 (c) SER 3 (d) SER 4 (e) SER 5 (f) SER 6 (g) SER 7 (h) SER 8

Fig. 6: Detection overview showing predicted nodule bounding boxes (red) using RetinaNet with Focal Loss and SE Resnet Bottleneck [11] on the LUNA16 dataset.

ment techniques and led to exploring attention-driven backbones to improve detection performance.

C. *Effect of Bottleneck Modifications*

We concentrated on editing the bottleneck blocks in the ResNet backbone to include localized attention mechanisms that could direct feature channels to be more task-informative without changing the base structure of the RetinaNet [7] framework.

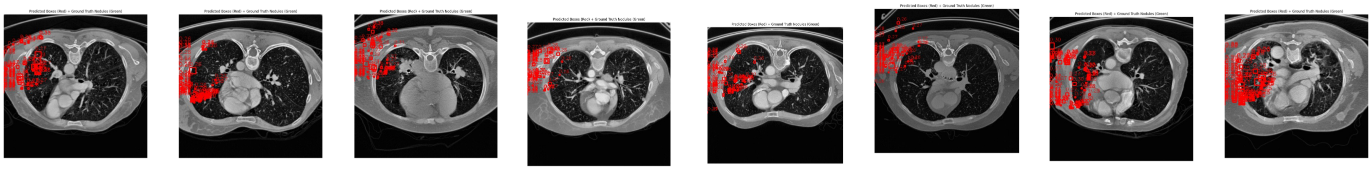
The SEBottleneck [10], incorporating lightweight channel-wise attention via squeeze-and-excitation (SE) blocks, enabled the network to adaptively reweight feature channels based on their relevance. It helped improve the network's ability to detect faint or small nodules.

The SEResNet bottleneck [11] integrated SE attention with a deeper residual structure, capturing richer feature hierarchies while selectively amplifying key responses. It showed enhanced sensitivity, particularly in identifying nodules with irregular morphology or overlapping tissues.

The SEResNeXt bottleneck [12] couples grouped convolutions with channel attention. Its architecture encourages diversified feature extraction through multiple parallel transformation paths, improving robustness to anatomical variability and reducing false positives.

Improvements across all modified bottleneck blocks stemmed from the enhanced ability to selectively focus on diagnostically relevant channels.

In direct comparison, the attention-enhanced backbones



(a) SERX 1 (b) SERX 2 (c) SERX 3 (d) SERX 4 (e) SERX 5 (f) SERX 6 (g) SERX 7 (h) SERX 8

Fig. 7: Detection overview showing predicted nodule bounding boxes (red) using RetinaNet with Focal Loss and SE Resnext Bottleneck [12] on the LUNA16 dataset.

with SE Bottleneck [10] introduced offered noticeable qualitative improvements over the baseline.

D. Comparative Summary and Key Findings

An augmented comparison of architectures from baseline ResNet to the optimized SE architectures unveils certain general trends and provides insight into how the design of a backbone can influence lung nodule detection performance.

It will be noted that the baseline RetinaNet [7] with ResNet formed a very solid basis by effectively detecting the majority of nodules under normal conditions. The lack of attention mechanisms, however, rendered it inconsistent while dealing with complex or ambiguous cases, especially those with minimal nodules or overlapping anatomical structures.

Modification of bottleneck blocks using SEBottleneck [10], SEResNet bottleneck [11], and SEResNeXt bottleneck [12] showed that even localized attention can benefit feature refinement immensely. These improvements were most evident in cluttered image regions, where the network's ability to prioritize relevant channels led to more reliable predictions.

These results emphasize that incremental architectural changes can accumulate into meaningful performance gains when thoughtfully applied. The combination of deep residual learning, channel-wise attention, and diversified convolution strategies forms a powerful foundation for medical object detection—one that is both sensitive to small lesions and resilient to variability in clinical imaging data.

E. Implications for Future Research

The outcomes of this study open several avenues for further research in medical image detection, particularly in the design and optimization of backbone architectures for deep learning models. While our experiments demonstrated the benefits of incorporating attention mechanisms and grouped convolutions, there remains significant potential to explore additional architectural innovations and training strategies.

One promising direction involves the integration of spatial attention mechanisms alongside channel-wise attention. This holds the possibility of improved performance, especially for the detection of small nodules that lie adjacent to complex structures such as the chest wall and vessels.

There is much-unexplored potential in merging CNN backbone models with transformer-based types of modules. Vision Transformers (ViTs) [13] and hybrid CNN-transformer models have shown great promise in various computer vision tasks, particularly for their ability to capture global context and long-range dependencies. Incorporating such components could further enhance the model's ability to differentiate subtle lesions from visually similar tissues.

From a training perspective, approaches like semi-supervised learning and self-supervised pretraining could be particularly useful in medical domains where annotated data is limited. Leveraging unlabeled data through contrastive learning or pseudo-labeling could help strengthen feature learning and reduce the reliance on large-scale manual annotations.

Additionally, extending the evaluation to multi-institutional and heterogeneous datasets would provide a better understanding of model generalizability in real-world clinical settings. Investigating domain adaptation techniques could also help in deploying these models across different scanner types or patient populations.

Finally, interpretability remains a critical consideration for medical AI. Future work could explore attention map visualization, uncertainty estimation, or clinician-in-the-loop feedback to make these models not only accurate but also trustworthy and actionable in a clinical workflow.

VI. Conclusion

In this study, we investigated the influence of backbone architecture variations in a RetinaNet [7] -based deep learning framework for the detection of lung nodules in CT images. Beginning with a standard ResNet bottleneck as the baseline, we explored three enhanced bottleneck variants—SEBottleneck [10], SEResNet bottleneck [11], and SEResNeXt bottleneck [12] —to improve the network's ability to detect subtle nodules through attention-driven feature refinement.

Through extensive experimentation using 10-fold cross-validation [9] on a curated dataset of preprocessed CT scan slices, we observed that all attention-augmented backbones offered qualitative improvements over the baseline. The inclusion of channel-wise attention in SEBottleneck [10] and SEResNet [11] enabled the model to better prioritize informative features while suppressing noise, particularly in low-contrast or complex anatomical regions. The SEResNeXt bottleneck [12] , with its multi-branch and group convolution structure, provided the most comprehensive feature extraction, leading to improved robustness and detection accuracy.

These results highlight the significant role backbone design plays in enhancing the performance of convolutional detectors, especially for sensitive and high-stakes tasks in medical imaging. Future work may focus on integrating spatial attention mechanisms, experimenting with hybrid CNN-transformer backbones, or applying similar enhancements to other medical imaging tasks beyond nodule detection.

Ultimately, this study demonstrates that even within a well-established detection architecture, architectural innovations at the feature extraction level can meaningfully advance the state of the art in automated lung nodule detection.

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